

Handout - *Fiction, Myth, and Reality* Parts 3 & 4

The central problem

Salmon argues that recent attempts, especially **Kripke's intensional-ascent strategy**, do **not** solve the problem. They merely relocate it. If there is no referent for "Holmes" in the relevant sense, then moving to formulations like "the proposition that Holmes used cocaine" does not help, because that proposition-term becomes just as problematic as the original name (pp. 63–65).

Salmon's solution

Salmon's positive view is that names like "**Sherlock Holmes**" are **not ambiguous** between a nondesignating use and a use naming a fictional artifact. Rather, their genuine, literal use is as names for **artifactual abstract entities**: fictional characters created by authors. Holmes is real **as a fictional character**, though not real **as a flesh-and-blood detective** (pp. 68–75).

That lets Salmon preserve:

- the **meaningfulness** of fictional and metafictional discourse,
 - the **univocity** of fictional names,
 - and a broadly **Millian/direct-reference** framework without collapsing into Meinongianism or heavy Fregean intensionality.
-

III. Why Kripke's intensional ascent fails

Salmon begins by rejecting Kripke's proposal that we handle empty names by ascending to propositions or proposition-like entities. The key complaint is that the strategy generates an **infinite regress** (p. 63).

Main objection

If "Holmes 1" is thoroughly nondesignating, then:

- "the proposition that Holmes 1 used cocaine" is equally suspect.
- And then:
 - "There is no proposition that Holmes 1 used cocaine" itself contains the same underlying problem.

- So the original semantic difficulty has not been solved, only reformulated (pp. 63–64).

If the original fictional sentence expresses nothing, then how can the metafictional sentence built on it express something true?

Why this matters for metafiction

Salmon insists that sentences like:

- “**According to the Holmes stories, Holmes used cocaine**”
- “**On Le Verrier’s theory, Vulcan influences Mercury’s orbit**”

are plainly meaningful and often true in the relevant sense. But if there is **no proposition** that Holmes used cocaine, what exactly is true *according to the stories*? What did readers grasp? What did Le Verrier believe? (p. 64)

This is the pressure point: Kripke’s account threatens to make **truth in fiction** and **belief about myth** mysterious rather than explicable.

Cross-realm predication

Salmon also raises the problem of statements like:

- “**Sherlock Holmes was cleverer than Bertrand Russell**”
- “**Sherlock Holmes was cleverer than Hercule Poirot**” (p. 64)

These are especially difficult if fictional names are treated as involving nondesignating or quasi-intensional uses. Kripke seems forced into what Salmon calls a kind of “**quasi-intensional**” machinery, reminiscent of **Fregean ungrade** (indirect) contexts (pp. 64–65).

Why Salmon thinks this is unacceptable

Salmon’s complaint is not merely that Kripke’s theory is complicated. It is that it is complicated **in the wrong way**:

- it reintroduces the very sort of **intensional apparatus** that direct-reference theorists typically reject;
- it threatens to imply that if some real person were sufficiently **Holmesesque**, then there might be true propositions that Holmes existed or used cocaine;
- this would make Holmes’s “existence” depend on the accidental discovery of a resembling real detective, which Salmon takes to be absurd (p. 65).

So the verdict of Part III is pointed: **Kripke's solution is both semantically unstable and metaphysically misguided.**

IV. Salmon's positive theory: fictional names are names of abstract artifacts

Part IV supplies the constructive account. Salmon's headline claim is that "**Sherlock Holmes**" is **not ambiguous** in the way Kripke suggests (p. 66).

1. Conan Doyle was not literally referring to a man

When Doyle wrote the Holmes stories, he was **pretending** to use "Sherlock Holmes" as the name of a detective. But pretending to refer is not the same thing as actually referring unsuccessfully. Salmon draws here on J. O. Urmson's point: the author of fiction is not performing ordinary acts of **assertion** or **reference** at all (pp. 66–67).

This is crucial. Salmon denies there is a prior genuine use of the name on which it is a failed name for a man. Instead:

- there is first a **pretense** of such a use,
- and then there is a genuine use of the name as naming the **fictional character** created in the story (pp. 68–69).

2. Fictional characters are abstract artifacts

Holmes is not a nonexistent detective. Holmes is an **abstract artifact**, created by Conan Doyle, much as the story itself is created (p. 68).

This lets Salmon say:

- **according to the story**, Holmes is a man, detective, violinist, cocaine user, etc.;
- **in reality**, Holmes is an abstract entity.

This distinction between **truth in the fiction** and **truth in reality** is foundational for the whole account.

3. Object-fictional vs. metafictional discourse

Salmon treats fictional sentences such as:

- **“Sherlock Holmes uses cocaine”**

as expressing singular propositions about the fictional character Holmes. Taken literally, these are mostly **false**, since abstract artifacts do not use cocaine (pp. 70, 72).

But they are **true with respect to the fiction** because they are entailed by the propositions comprising the story, together with background assumptions about the world (p. 72).

This gives Salmon an account of:

- **object-fictional discourse**: sentences occurring “within” the fiction,
- **metafictional discourse**: sentences like “According to the Holmes stories, Holmes used cocaine” (pp. 72–73).

That is one of the strongest features of the view: it explains not only why fictional discourse is meaningful, but also how **truth in fiction** works.

The issue of negative existentials

A major payoff comes when Salmon turns to:

- **“Sherlock Holmes does not really exist; he is only a fictional character”** (p. 73)

Taken strictly literally, this is close to contradiction, since Holmes *does* exist—as a fictional character. So why do ordinary speakers say such things?

Salmon’s answer

In these contexts, the name is often being used in a **descriptive** (or **Pickwickian**) way. “Sherlock Holmes” may mean something like:

- *Holmes as depicted in the stories,*
- *the person who is both Holmes and Holmesesque* (pp. 74–75).

So when someone says “Sherlock Holmes does not exist,” what they usually mean is:

- there is **no real person** corresponding to Holmes-as-depicted.

This preserves ordinary usage without conceding that the fundamental semantic role of the name is nondesignating.